

World in Brief: Israel and Hizbullah agree to a ceasefire; ministers urge Keir Starmer to resign



Photograph: Getty Images

Israel and **Hizbullah** agreed to an immediate ceasefire, according to American officials. Israel had continued to strike the Iranian-backed group in Lebanon despite American objections, putting the [peace agreement](#) between Iran and America in jeopardy. Israeli officials told local media that their forces will remain in southern Lebanon and will respond to any further attacks.

Government ministers, including reportedly the transport secretary, Heidi Alexander, urged **Sir Keir Starmer** to set a timetable for his resignation. Britain's prime minister faces an imminent leadership challenge from **Andy Burnham**, Greater Manchester's former mayor who was [elected as an MP](#) on Friday. Mr Burnham vowed to "lay out a new path for Britain". Sir Keir says he will take part in any contest.

J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, delayed a planned trip to meet Iranian negotiators in Switzerland, citing logistical issues. They were set to discuss the implementation of the agreement signed by the presidents of America and Iran this week. Earlier Mr Vance scolded Israeli cabinet members for criticising Donald

Trump's [deal](#). He said the American president is “the only head of state in the entire world” sympathetic to [Israel](#).

Norway said it will ban the use of AI in primary schools, and [restrict the technology](#) in secondary schools. The country's prime minister, Jonas Gahr Store, said schools must teach children “to read, write and do mathematics”, and cited falling test scores. Smartphones are already verboten in Norway's classrooms; social media will be banned for under-16s by the end of the year.

America will phase out funding for its AIDS-relief programme in **South Africa**, in place since 2003, because the country has failed to “make demonstrable progress on policy requests by the administration”. Mr Trump has accused South Africa's government of fuelling violence against the country's [white minority](#) and seizing land without compensation. As much as 12% of the population has HIV.

Mojtaba Khamenei, [Iran's supreme leader](#), wrote in a statement that Mr Trump agreed to a deal “out of desperation”. In-person negotiations with America do not mean “acceptance of the enemy's position”, he added. Meanwhile, America lifted its naval blockade on the Strait of Hormuz; **petrol prices** in America fell below \$4 a gallon on average for the first time since March 30th.

World Cup favourites dominated the tournament's first week, with wins for Germany (7-1 over Curaçao), Argentina (3-0 over Algeria), France (3-1 over Senegal) and England (4-2 over Croatia). Underdogs defied expectations as Cape Verde, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and Morocco drew against Spain, Portugal, and Brazil, respectively. Canada, the tournament's co-host, claimed its first-ever men's World Cup victory, defeating Qatar, 6-0. America and Mexico also made winning starts.

Figure of the day: \$22bn, the amount Fox paid, in cash and stock, for Roku, a streaming platform. [Read about how](#) the cable giant is

planning to shake up the streaming wars.

How closely have you followed the headlines this week? Prove your topical chops in our latest [news quiz](#).

US in Brief: Meet America's next socialist mayor



Photograph: AP

Janeese Lewis George won the Democratic primary for the mayor's race in Washington, DC. The 38-year-old's victory in November's election, which is almost certain, would continue a streak of mayoral victories for Democratic Socialists in big American cities, including Zohran Mamdani in New York and Katie Wilson in Seattle. Ms Lewis George's success in the primary will [upset Donald Trump](#): he has threatened to "take back" the capital and run it on a federal basis should she become mayor.

In **Maine**, Matt Dunlap, a left-wing Democrat, won the party's primary for a critical congressional seat. He will run against the state's former Republican governor, Paul LePage, in November. The Republicans spy a chance to flip the seat after the Democratic incumbent, Jared Golden, said he would not seek re-election. Meanwhile, Hannah Pingree won the Democratic nomination for the governor's race after a run-off, and will face Bobby Charles, a MAGA Republican.

Republican criticism of Mr Trump's interim deal with Iran intensified, even as the White House delivered the document to Congress. The Republican chair of the Senate Armed Forces Committee, Roger Wicker, said the agreement "negotiates away the victories" of the war, particularly with the creation of a \$300bn

reconstruction fund for Iran. J.D. Vance, the vice-president, defended the deal and called it a “win for the American people”.

Pete Hegseth, the defence secretary, said the Pentagon would begin a six-month review into the deployment of [American forces in Europe](#). He also once again lashed out at NATO allies over their defence spending and response to Mr Trump’s war in Iran. In May America said it would withdraw 5,000 troops from Germany. The comments set the stage for an awkward NATO summit in Turkey next month.

No talks between Vance and Iran, for now



Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

With one deal done, it should be time to negotiate the next—but not yet, it seems. J.D. Vance, America’s vice-president, had been due to meet Iranian officials in Switzerland on Friday. Their talks were to be a first step towards implementing the accord signed by both countries’ presidents this week. But the meeting was called off at the last minute. Mr Vance cited logistical issues: “These negotiations have never been simple or predictable,” said his spokesperson. Some reports suggest the Iranian delegates stayed home to protest against Israeli strikes in Lebanon.

The abrupt cancellation is an early example of how difficult it will be for America and Iran to reach a final accord, which they are meant to do within 60 days. Donald Trump tried twice before to clinch a nuclear pact with Iran. Both attempts ended in failure (and war). The lead negotiators on both sides—the speaker of Iran’s parliament, and Mr Vance—are relatively pragmatic. But anything they agree on is likely to prove controversial at home—even more than the process has already.

The mystery of Aung San Suu Kyi



Photograph: Shutterstock

Aung San Suu Kyi turned 81 on Friday. Jailed after the army ousted her government in a coup in 2021, the former de facto leader of [Myanmar](#) is being held in solitary confinement as part of a 27-year prison sentence on fabricated charges. After the junta rigged recent elections, a few political prisoners were released, but not Ms Suu Kyi. It is not known where she is, or even whether she is alive. Myanmar's state-controlled media reports that she was recently moved from prison to "house arrest". But her supporters are sceptical.

Her son, Kim Aris, is leading a worldwide campaign to demand an independently verified "proof of life". To attract attention to his mother's plight he has skateboarded 81km in London. Despite losing international respect after she defended her country when it was accused of genocide against the Rohingya, she remains popular among her fellow Burmese. Alive or dead, she casts a long shadow over Myanmar.

Can Reliance tempt investors back to India?



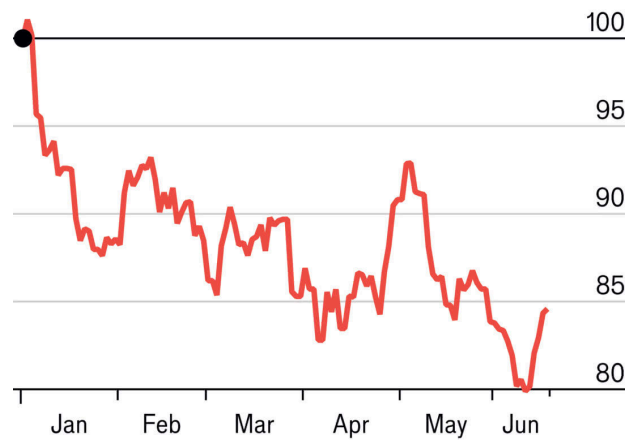
Photograph: Reuters

Reliance, one of India's biggest conglomerates, held its annual general meeting on Friday. The firm, run by [Mukesh Ambani](#), Asia's second-richest man, has had a tough year. Its colossal oil refinery depends on imports of the fuel—prices of which have surged in recent months. The peace deal between America and Iran may have injected some optimism into the meeting.

So will the plans for the listing of Jio, officially announced on Friday. Since Reliance's telecoms arm launched in 2016, it has driven India's smartphone revolution, providing cheap data to hundreds of millions. The listing is expected to raise \$4bn, making it India's biggest. Following a run of bumper years for listings, there have been few Indian IPOs in 2026 as many were put on hold when the Iran war knocked investors' confidence. Markets have suffered, too, as foreign investors have ditched Indian equities in favour of those from Asian countries with big AI firms. Plans like this could be just what the public markets need.

Unreliable

Reliance Industries, share price,
Jan 1st 2026=100



Source: LSEG Workspace

North Korea tries to build bridges



Photograph: Getty Images

The first road bridge connecting Russia and North Korea was supposed to open on Friday to mark the two-year anniversary of the countries' mutual-defence treaty. But satellite imagery shows construction is unfinished on the Russian side of the Tumen river. The delay is but a hiccup in their plans for closer transport links. Rail traffic between the two countries has picked up; direct flights between Moscow and Pyongyang resumed last year.

In part, this reflects the growing number of Russian tourists flocking to North Korea, and North Korean workers toiling in Russia. But military co-operation is at the heart of [their closer](#) relationship. North Korea has supported Russia's war in Ukraine with thousands of troops and shipments of artillery shells, missiles and rockets. In return it has received advanced technologies, food and cash. The cosiness has even brought North Korea a new friend: Belarus. The hermit kingdom will be glad to have another dictatorship in its Rolodex.

Netflix will find you



Photograph: Netflix

Should you open Netflix this week, the words “I WILL FIND YOU” will appear. They feel more like a threat than a title: “Harlan Coben’s I WILL FIND YOU” is the latest series based on the novels of Mr Coben, an American thriller writer. Previous adaptations have proved popular. In 2024 Harlan Coben’s “Fool Me Once” was watched for almost a quarter of a billion hours in the week of its release.

Mr Coben’s nail-biters are packed full of mysteries: missing daughters, vanished wives, lost husbands. They offer meta-mysteries too, like: how do the characters, who have such ordinary jobs, have such extraordinary kitchens? And: why is Netflix so fixated on Mr Coben? Above all: why does his name get such prominent billing, when another author, called [Jane Austen](#), often appears in much smaller font? At least Mr Coben can clear that last one up. An early series, he says, sounded too much like another, so to differentiate “they put my name above the title”.

Daily Quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What great event began at a bakery in Pudding Lane in 1666?

Thursday: Who was nominated for his role as best supporting actor in the film "Sideways"?

*Ambition: it is the last infirmity of
noble minds.*

J.M. Barrie